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THE FILM MERCURY

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FRIDAY, JULY 27, 1928Edited by
TAMAR LANE

New Line-up at First National

Warner Stock Takes A Boom

Tamar Lane

L. J. SELZNICK IN BIG TALKIE DEAL?

Among the most interesting news of the week is the report to the effect that Lewis J. Selznick is not only throwing his hat back into the movie ring, but he is already entering negotiations to take over the Cortellaphone talking device.

A dispatch from the East says that "L. J." is now under way with a deal to acquire control of the Cortella Synchronic Pictures Corp., an organization manufacturing sound equipment and sound productions independent of the so-called sound film "trust."

Lewis J. Selznick is a clever organizer and promoter and if he gets going with a talking device he is going to make the big film companies, as well as the Electrical Research outfit, do a little worrying.

"L. J." has long been one of the most outstanding figures in the film industry and there is always some interesting news for the papers when he begins to operate.

IS SID MAKING
ANOTHER BLUNDER?

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Tamar Lane

Continued from Front Page

According to announcements, Sid Grauman has selected "White Shadows of the South Seas" as the next attraction at the Hollywood Chinese Theatre. This would make it appear as though Grauman is going to lower the standard of his theatre and perhaps charge cut-price admissions.

"White Shadows" is an entertaining picture of scenic beauty, but it is not of the magnitude or lavishness that local theatregoers have come to expect from Grauman. With sound synchronization and a prologue the production may be built up in a manner that will attract good business to the theatre. In the long run, however, such presentations as these can only weaken Grauman's prestige as a showman of super productions.

* * *

Tivoli, London, Sold By M-G-M

London.—The Tivoli, famous London movie theatre where "Ben Hur" made a record run of more than a year, has been sold by Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer for a price which has not been made public, it was learned this week.

The buyer is the Provincial Cinematograph Theatres, Ltd., who have purchased 90 per cent of the stock. It is understood the famous Strand picture house will be devoted to the presentation of "talkies" which are just being introduced in Europe.

Warner Stock Takes a Boom

While The Film Mercury has constantly cautioned members of the film colony against investing in highly touted stocks, and in several instances accurately predicted their downfall, readers will recall that a short time ago The Film Mercury stated that Warner Bros. stock was a good buy and due for an upward movement in Wall St.

At the time The Film Mercury advised the purchase of Warner Bros. stock — about three weeks ago—it was selling at \$35 a share. Warner stock has taken a boom as forecast and is this week selling at over \$60—a jump of over \$25 a share in less than a month for any one who bought at the time The Film Mercury recommended.

It is highly probable that Warner stock will go several points higher, but from now on the stock becomes a speculation pure and simple. It is not a safe, permanent investment at anything over \$50. Those who have the inside dope on what is being done with the stock may still be able to trade it in and make a profit, but extreme caution should be used.

* * *

Barry Norton Loaned

Barry Norton, Fox Films player, has been loaned to Paramount to play the leading juvenile in "The Sins of the Fathers," Emil Jannings' next starring vehicle.

* * *

Leonard to Direct

Robert Z. Leonard will direct Norma Shearer in "The Last of Mrs. Cheyney," her next starring picture for M-G-M.

Rockett Appointed Head Of First National Production

As forecast in last week's *Film Mercury*, and its previous issues, the long expected shake-up in First National production ranks has taken place.

Al Rockett has been placed in charge of all First National Studio activities, as well as actual production at the Burbank plant, according to announcement by Joseph P. Kennedy, special advisor for First National Pictures, who is now in California.

Several other changes were made through resignation by members of the Burbank staff. David H. Thompson, assistant production manager; George Stout, head of the operating department; A. W. Allison, chief of the accounting department; Ralph Poucher, newly appointed head of Firatone, and Miss Harriet Morris, chief of the research department, are leaving their positions.

From the New York office

came announcement of the resignation of Richard A. Rowland, vice-president and general manager of First National Pictures, as also Mrs. Florence Strauss, head of the reading department, and Samuel Spring, secretary and treasurer.

Rockett has been in charge of production for First National for the past year.

The Burbank studios of First National will produce close to sixty feature-length pictures during the coming year, the largest production schedule in the history of the organization. Rockett will guide the destinies of these pictures, and also handle the management of the studio personnel.

* * *

Harry Braxton Titles M-G-M Production

Harry Braxton is writing the titles for "Morgan's Last Raid," M-G-M production, starring Tim McCoy.

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The New York Angle On Films

By OLIVER UNDERWOOD

New York—One large sized glass of ice water has been thrown on the superheated enthusiasm for talkie production. Western Electric has made public announcement of the fact that it has on hand 799 contracts for the installation of talkie projectors in as many theatres, all of which will be completed by January 1st, 1929. Nearly 400 are already equipped.

To the casual onlooker that looks like great progress. But sales managers of the various big line companies are having cold shivers up and down their spines, wondering how a maximum of 799 theatres are going to be made to pay the cost of synchronizing 158 feature pictures this coming season.

Perhaps that doesn't mean anything to you. Look at it this way. It means there will be one feature production for every five theatres that can use it. If the same proportion was maintained throughout the industry there would be something like 4,400 features made in America each year to supply the 22,000 theatres.

That shows how over supplied the talkie field will be and why sales managers are going gray headed and praying that production managers will stick to the silent pictures and be satisfied with sound effects. That will give them a chance to stick some of the talkie cost over onto the silent theatres. The first few talkies, however, should make plenty of money.

Of course, these figures only cover the Western Electric projecting apparatus, but Western Electric apparatus is only for W. E. licensed productions, and the W. E. licensed productions are for projection only on W. E. equipment. The 156 features tabulated above are those announced only by W. E. licensed companies.

New York exhibitors established an unique record this past week. Three pre-release houses, all competitors of each

other, in fact within a radius of five streets of each other, hung up new attendance records for the respective houses, during weather that was sweltering hot for five days of the seven and which provided heavy thunder showers on the other two. The theatres are the Roxy, the Paramount and the Strand.

The Roxy had "The Street Angel" for the first time at popular prices, with a synchronized musical score and some sound effects. The Strand was in its second week with the all talkie feature "Lights of New York."

None of the houses established new weekly gross receipts records, but both the Roxy and the Paramount established new receipt records per show. This despite lower admissions, due to the abolition of the amusement tax the latter part of June. The Strand is operating on a lower admission basis than ever existed at the house, so the receipts did not break the best records, but the attendance did.

The Roxy and the Strand hold over their shows this week. Dix in "Warming Up" was transferred to the Rivoli where it will run with its synchronized sound effects, but will be minus the stage show it had at the Paramount.

The surprise of the week in the theatre field was the flop registered by "The King of Kings." It was withdrawn from the Rivoli after two weeks, during which time it grossed less than "Ramona" did in any one week of its extended run at the same theatre. This despite the fact that it was the first time this DeMille special has been shown at popular prices, and it also had the advantage of a synchronized musical score with some sound effects during the storm and after the crucifixion, which has seldom been equalled in the canned music field.

It is worthy of note that ten

out of the twenty-one productions listed as "selected pictures" this month by the National Board of Review are made from stories written directly for the screen. Those screen authors who acquired this distinction are: Frances Marion with "The Cossacks;" Wellyn Totman with "Green Grass Widows;" Edmund Goulding with "Happiness Ahead;" Ernest Booth with "Ladies of the Mob;" Ernest Pascal with "Man-made Women;" H. L. Gates and Eleanor Browne with "The Red Dance;" John Russell with "The Red Mark;" Gale Van Every with "Telling the World;" C. Gardner Sullivan with "The Tempest," and R. L. Rigby with "The Toilers."

* * *

Church, Then Films; And It's in Iowa!

St. Joseph, Mo.—Conway, Iowa, has no Sunday movie question. Church services are held every Sunday night in an open-air theatre. The services end promptly at 8:30 o'clock and the congregation may then leave or pay an admission price and see a six-reel film. Everybody seems to be satisfied and the motion picture theatre owners say their crowds have increased.

* * *

Film Life of Columbus

United Artists will make a film based on the life and career of Christopher Columbus. Fred Niblo will direct the production.

* * *

\$150,000 Film Suit

Charges Monopoly

Omaha,—Suit for \$150,000 damages against the Omaha Film Board of Trade and the Omaha branches of nine nationally known motion picture distributing agencies was filed in Federal Court here recently by owners of a suburban theatre. Victor Newton and Thomas H. Leddy, the plaintiffs, charge a monopoly.

ANABEL LANE

Says

The present amazing vogue for talkies will leave the theatres that are showing only the silent movies in a serious situation. The only logical way that they can meet this condition will be by lowering their admission prices. With the poor financial state existing in this country a small entrance fee should prove inviting.

A prediction made some months ago—before the sound cinemas became popular is repeated now—that motion picture theatres will have to lower their admission cost, even the "talkies" will not be able to hold up the high prices over a period of time. Already the Strand in New York has lowered theirs—and this gesture will be but the forerunner for the other theatres to follow.

—

Although we critics have been unanimous in harpooning John Barrymore for selling out to the celluloid art, he no doubt will have the laugh on us. For the voice has always been this actor's forte. While he has gradually been sliding downward in the screen firmament the last few years, he will probably regain for himself the title of the first actor of the land.

—

Hollywood already shows promise of being overcrowded in the field for voice teachers. They are arriving from New York, Europe and elsewhere. Actors, stage and concert singers, are announcing they are ready to teach. An amusing note in this condition is that Hollywood ever ready to choose the foreigner over the American does not realize the importance of correct pronunciation and they are flocking to a few Europeans who should first learn to talk English before teaching it.

* * *

Will Direct Denny

Joseph Henaberry has been engaged to direct Reginald Denny's next comedy production for Universal, "Red Hot Speed."

THE FILM PARADE

As seen by RICHARD WATTS Jr.

The importance of personality in motion pictures was pretty effectively demonstrated again last week, with the presentation in rival theatres of films starring such eminent performers as Richard Dix and William Haines. Dix appeared in a baseball comedy called "Warming Up" and Haines was under observation in a newspaper drama called "Telling the World," and neither work was a particularly important one. Any difference in their quality, in fact, was almost entirely due to the respective work of their stars. Well, "Warming Up" was a fairly good picture and "Telling the World" was simply terrible.

Of course, there are those observers who hold out strenuously for the claim that the baseball film was the more effective of the two because it was provided with sound effects to represent the noises made by the crowds and the players on the occasion of a World's Series game. This belief, even if true, is of scant help to the talking films because the accompaniment to "Warming Up" was little more than that provided by a competent orchestra and those usual off-screen noises used in every well-scored film. And, as a matter of fact, it is of little help to Mr. Haines, either. For despite any extraneous aid, "Warming Up" was a better picture than "Telling the World" only through the superiority of Richard Dix over William Haines. The differences would be equally noticeable if both pictures were run off in complete silence.

The important thing is that Dix is an engaging, pleasant-mannered player who made the leading role of a rookie pitcher entirely sympathetic and completely believable in all his predicaments. To counteract this advantage of acting, "Telling the World" offered Mr.

Haines, who was fresh, bumptious, thoroughly unbelievable and entirely the show-off actor when he should have been representing a fairly human being. It is my carefully considered opinion that by his work in his newest picture he proves himself conclusively the most annoying performer on the American screen.

It is undeniably true that my objection to Haines is based less on a matter of acting than, as I confessed at the outset, a question of personality. But I think I have a pretty good case against the cinema's Show Off in the field of histrionics, too. In "Telling the World" he is supposed to be a fresh young man looking for a job on a newspaper. He bursts in on the city editor, pushes his way into a job, is generally fresh and obstreperous and full of cute tricks, and, as result of his antics, he becomes little less than the pride of the office. Yet you know all the time that if a cub reporter rushed into a newspaper and acted in the William Haines manner he would have fled for his life or have been tossed quietly out of the building.

There really isn't a moment in which Haines is believable in "Telling the World." As a newspaper man he is a joke, and as a fascinating devil who simply bowls every one over by his charm, he is even worse. He is constantly being fresh and wisecracking and cheaply arrogant and generally insufferable. He is just too constantly full of tricks for words. He is the sort of man who slaps you resoundingly on the back, shakes your hand until it hurts, plays practical jokes and says, "And how!" He is never at a loss for a new way to express wearisome blatancy. In a word he is the sort of man you would either run a block to avoid or would walk a mile or two for

a chance to hit over the head. Yet on the screen you are supposed to accept him as just the most charming and freshly engaging young rascal extant.

It is not, I should perhaps add, that I insist on film heroes being of the retiring, wistful, Charles Ray type. As a matter of act the old shrinking violet leading man was beginning to get just a bit annoying, too. But Mr. Haines carries the thing too far. Even he must have moments in which he doubts whether he is quite the perfection of fascinating masculinity. In his films, though, he goes right ahead being 100 per cent pleased with himself. Compared to him George Kelly's Aubrey Piper and Carl Laemmle's Glenn Tryon are runners-up to Harry Langdon as representatives of wistfulness and the inferiority complex.

This incredible Haines character puts a very considerable burden on the back of the supporting players, too. They all have to stand around and pretend to admire the young man and still make you believe in what they are doing. Particularly was this noticeable last week in the case of Miss Anita Page, the adoring ingenue of "Telling the World." Miss Page is a pretty child and a likeable one but when she has to convince you that she just adores the antics of her stalwart star, she is really too nice for you to believe such a thing of her. And when she is forced to get very tearful because she feels she isn't worthy of the gallant youth, you just can't share her tears over the matter.

Meanwhile Mr. Dix in "Warming Up," was making a juvenile and not especially believable baseball romance good entertainment by a particularly engaging performance. There is nothing of that unbearable freshness, that insufferable ar-

rogance of the Haines characterization about it. Mr. Dix's rookie was simple, credible, quietly amusing and thoroughly likeable and so he adds to the film a disarming quality that makes you overlook many of its faults. Mr. Haines' portrayal, on the other hand, makes the defects of story stand out all the more vigorously. And he wasn't a bad actor either, once.

* * *

Al Jolson Signed

For New Vitaphones

Al Jolson has been signed by Warner Brothers to appear in more productions for that company. Upon completion of his current production Jolson will leave for the East to appear in his new stage vehicle, "Mister Bones." After a season on the stage he will return to Hollywood to appear in some new Vitaphone pictures.

* * *

Turpin In Vaudeville

Ben Turpin, screen comedian, is starting on a vaudeville tour.

* * *

McCormicks to Travel

Colleen Moore and John McCormick, her husband, are leaving Hollywood for a trip of several weeks.

* * *

To Direct New One

Mervyn LeRoy, First National director, will handle the megaphone on "Rosie of the Ritz," starring Alice White.

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Short Dramas Should Be Encouraged

Recently a number of Hollywoodites entered the short reel drama field. They had noticed the unfavorable reaction of audiences, exhibitors and writers against the dreadful two-reel comedies. Bravely these pioneers invested their small savings in attempting something a little out of the ordinary. While they have been fairly successful in their adventures they have not received the encouragement or acknowledgement that their efforts justified.

The two-reel pictures unappropriately called comedies cost from \$5,000 to \$15,000. The films turned out by those who have started the short dramatic films have ranged from \$97 to \$1,000. With a substantial sum of money who can predict what these groups might make.

The exhibitors have not responded to these short subjects as fairly as they should. A few of these cinemas have been impressionistic and it is probable that some of the audiences did not enthuse over them. But to be honest the exhibitors should admit that many theatregoers become restless and impatient during the so-called two-reel comedy. Habit however, is so strong the theatre owners stick to the beaten path rather than take a step forward.

One of the films criticised was that directed by Robert Florey. It is called "Hollywood Extra 9413" and is an impressionistic satire. It is a brilliant, biting and correct expose of the experiences of an extra. Why it is difficult to understand I cannot comprehend. No doubt it is that those who are accustomed to see and laugh at a man kicking a woman in the slats, to roar at someone taking castor oil, fail to find any appreciation in something worthwhile. It takes a long time to even halfway educate the masses,*exhibitors and producers.

If this production had been made in Europe and heralded as a hit, it would, no doubt have created much talk and have been called a masterpiece.

My advice to the beginners in this movement for better short subjects is to continue. The dialogue in the talkies will hasten the Little Theatre movement, where eventually they will have to show better productions if they wish to survive and they will offer a market for artistic efforts. The commercial palaces also will find that they will have to offer something better than the putrid comedies they are now showing. So those who have been courageous enough to spend their hard earned money in this new field should keep a brave heart.

—ANABEL LANE.

Powell Assigned Role

William Powell has one of the featured leads in Paramount's production of "Interference," to be directed by Lothar Mendez. Clive Brook and Evelyn Brent have the other featured leads.

In Vaudeville

Mary Kornman, Johnny Downs and "Scooter" Lowry, original members of Hal Roach's "Our Gang" comedies, will appear at the Orpheum Theatre in Los Angeles starting Sunday, July 29.

DIALOGUE — TITLES — EDITING

ALFRED HUSTWICK

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PRODUCTION



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WARNER BROTHERS

VIEWS AND REVIEWS

"CELEBRITY."

A P.D.C.-Pathe release.
Directed by Tay Garnett.
Continuity by George Drumgold and Tay Garnett.
Cast includes Robert Armstrong, Lina Basquette and Clyde Cook.
Previewed at the Carmel Theatre.

Critical Viewpoint:

This film is apparently a take-off on Gene Tunney. It deals with a fighter whose manager gets the idea of presenting him as an intellectual and poetical gent. This opens the way for some fairly amusing comedy, especially in one sequence, where the "pug" delivers a speech before a women's club group.

Although there are no situations in the story of outstanding dramatic power, the affairs and experiences of the fighter and dapper manager are dealt with in an engaging manner, interwoven with enough love interest to round out the appeal of the picture. Several human touches have also been injected.

Some of the scenes between the fighter and the girl are slow and are played for too much footage. This makes the film drag in several spots.

In the championship boxing match, which serves as the climax in the story, there is nothing which shows why the hero suddenly comes to life and defeats the champion, after he is unmercifully beaten in the first round or two. This is not only unconvincing but it removes all thrill from the fight and should be remedied. More fight scenes are also needed. Tay Garnett has done well in his first directorial assignment. The situations as a whole are not only well staged but he has treated some of them in a novel manner and used effective but not overdone camera angles.

Clyde Cook takes first honors as the manager. Robert Armstrong is impressive in some scenes but misses in others.

Box Office Angle:

This is a light comedy-drama that should be fair entertainment for the majority of the atreagoers, if you can get them in. There is nothing much to exploit, except to advertise the fact that "Celebrity" is a satire on modern day pugilism.

—Tamar Lane.

* * *

Magnavox Gets Settlement in Patent Fight

Officials of the Magnavox Company have taken up the question of patent infringement with manufacturers of "talking movies," and have arrived at an amicable settlement with Western Electric Company, subsidiary of American Telephone and Telegraph, which manufactures sets for Warner Brothers' Motion Picture Company, according to a story released this week by the New York News Bureau.

Officials of Magnavox Company stated recently that all dynamic loud speakers not manufactured or licensed by the company are infringements of Magnavox patents. Sound motion pictures are using the principles of dynamic speakers.

Luddy Directing Lake

Edward Luddy is directing "The Soldier," in which Arthur Lake is being starred by Universal.

* * *

Beery With Gotham

Noah Beery has been signed by Harold Shumate of Gotham Productions for the initial talking picture to be made by that company.

Donovan Injured

Frank P. Donovan, producing the Short Story Classics at Tec-Art Studios, broke his ankle Monday afternoon and will be laid up for at least two weeks, according to his physician. Donovan has shipped his first two short classics, "The District Doctor" and "The Necklace" East.

Mountain Cabin for Sale

FOR SALE—Completely furnished Mountain Cabin with large victrola and radio—situated in the heart of the Malibu Mountains on lake with five and a half miles shore line. Only one hour by auto from Hollywood. Cost me about three thousand; worth twenty-five hundred, will take two thousand. This includes boat equipped for sailing, interest in boat house, membership in beautiful club and also stock in club. You will find the best fishing and hunting in Southern California. An ideal place for scenario writer or director seeking rest and quiet. Address Cabin Owner, care of Film Mercury.

JAMES A. STARR
TITLES AND DIALOGUE
"THE LITTLE WILDCAT"
DIRECTED BY
RAY ENRIGHT
WARNER BROTHERS

Broadway Film Chatter

By OLIVER UNDERWOOD

New York.—Just as things had quieted down in regard to the affiliations of producing companies with talkie systems, Irving Rossheim, president of First National Pictures and also of the Stanley Theatres company, threw a rock into the placid waters by announcing that First National had signed with Electrical Research Products, Inc., for at least thirty talkie pictures this coming year. That sounds like old news, the signing of First National for the use of Western Electric talkie process. Clifford B. Hawley, then president of the company made the same announcement some ten weeks ago.

Since then Mr. Rossheim became president and on the same day Joseph P. Kennedy, president of FBO, adviser to Pathe, and now spoken of as being the chairman of the executive committee of RCA Photophone, became adviser to FN. So a week ago it occasioned no surprise when FN announced that

its first synchronized picture "Lilac Time" would be done by the Photophone process, and the Central Theatre here, and the Carthay Circle in Hollywood would be wired by the Photophone system for the eastern and western premieres of this picture. Inquiries as to what FN had done with its Western Electric license were referred to Mr. Kennedy. E. B. Deer speaking for Kennedy said that the WE license which Mr. Hawley had announced had never been accepted by the signing the contract. WE admitted this.

The situation was thus when Kennedy, Deer and others of the Kennedy staff left New York on their present trip to Hollywood, with the announced intention of observing the FN production machinery and to remove any monkey wrenches if they found some interfering with the smooth running. While Kennedy is on the train Rossheim makes the announcement of the affiliation with W-

Small to Make Sound Pictures

Edward Small, independent producer, is to make a series of sound productions. Small is responsible for the alliance between Warner Brothers and Fannie Brice and it is reported that he may make the future Fannie Brice pictures.

Small has released most of his former productions through First National but it is not known through what channels he plans to release his sound films.

E. The big question which the industry is waiting an answer to is: Has Kennedy supreme power in First National? and if so, has he come to the conclusion that Electrical Research Products can keep Photophone off its projecting apparatus, and therefore has bowed to the inevitable and agreed to use the system which has made and is making 95% of all the theatre installations that have been ordered?

Paper Cinema Film Invented

Berlin.—Moving picture film made of paper, promising to revolutionize the movie industry, has been invented by a Berlin engineer after four years of secret experiments in a paper factory near Schwerin, in Mecklenburg.

The manufacture of a paper at once as transparent as glass and as flexible and strong as celluloid has been achieved, according to Berlin newspapers, but the name of the inventor is not revealed.

The paper film is expected to supplant celluloid for small movie apparatus such as is used in homes, but further development is required for use in regular movie apparatus the inventor states.

It is declared the paper film will make possible a reduction of 60 per cent in present costs. American film representatives here are skeptical about the possibility of paper films.

John The McDermott

The brilliant and clever young author wishes to announce in his usual modest and unassuming manner that he has just finished the story for the next Harold Lloyd production, which of course means that it will undoubtedly be the greatest success Mr. Lloyd has ever had.

It is possible at this time that Mr. McDermott could be approached in regard to a new assignment.

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